



THE WORLD OF BEES TODAY

Getting to know them, understanding them, protecting them

Dear friends, dear friends... and especially you, the little ones!

We start today this simple column, which will accompany us every fifteen days to discover a truly extraordinary world: the world of bees.

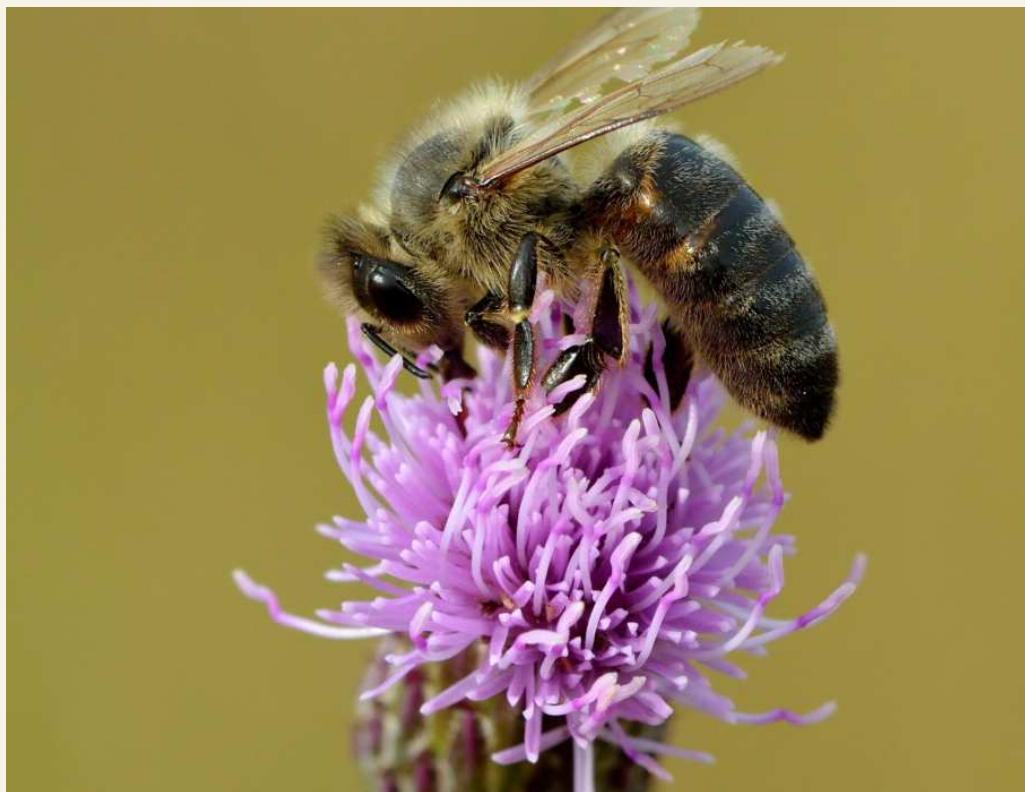
With simple words, curiosities and short stories we will try to get to know these precious insects better, understand how they live, how they work together and how important they are for nature and for all of us.

Naturally, this column also aims to be an open space for all of you: your testimonies, stories and photographs will be welcome, whether of a naturalistic nature or more closely related to the world of bees, hives, flowers and the surrounding environment.

You can also send us reports on environmental degradation, difficulties or problems affecting hives, observations on the health of bees and, more generally, anything that can help us better understand what is happening in the area.

Each testimony, photograph or report can become a small useful contribution to understand the problems, raise awareness and, where possible, help improve things together and protect the bees and their environment.

Sending you a warm greeting, we look forward to the next issue, to continue together this little journey into the wonderful world of bees.



Let's look at it up close

When it lands on a flower, the bee seems still. In reality it is working: the antennae explore, the legs seek support and the tongue reaches the nectar. Grainy pollen sticks to its furry body. Some will end up on another flower. Others will return to the hive, collected in the small baskets of the hind legs. A single visit already tells two stories: the nourishment of the colony and the life of the plants.

THE WORD



A house full of life

A hive is a colony, that is, a large family living together. There is a queen that lays eggs. There are thousands of workers that feed the young bees, build the comb, clean, defend and gather. Drones are the males and have a role in reproduction. The comb cells hold new bees and stores. Looking closely, the apparent disorder becomes a collective work.

Brood: it is the name for the eggs, larvae and bees that are growing.

DID YOU KNOW?



A day out

The bee leaves the hive when conditions allow. It searches for flowers, gathers nectar and pollen, then returns. If it finds a good food source, it can communicate to its companions where to find it through movements on the comb. The journey does not follow a clock: it depends on light, weather and blooms. And, among many similar entrances, the bee manages to find its own hive.

DID YOU KNOW?



Much more than honey

On a flower the bee looks for food. At the same time it carries pollen to other flowers of the same species: this is pollination. Thus many plants can produce seeds and fruits. Not all depend on bees and they are not the only pollinators: bumblebees, butterflies, flies and other animals take part in this work. Protecting pollinators means making room for a web of life larger than our honey jar.

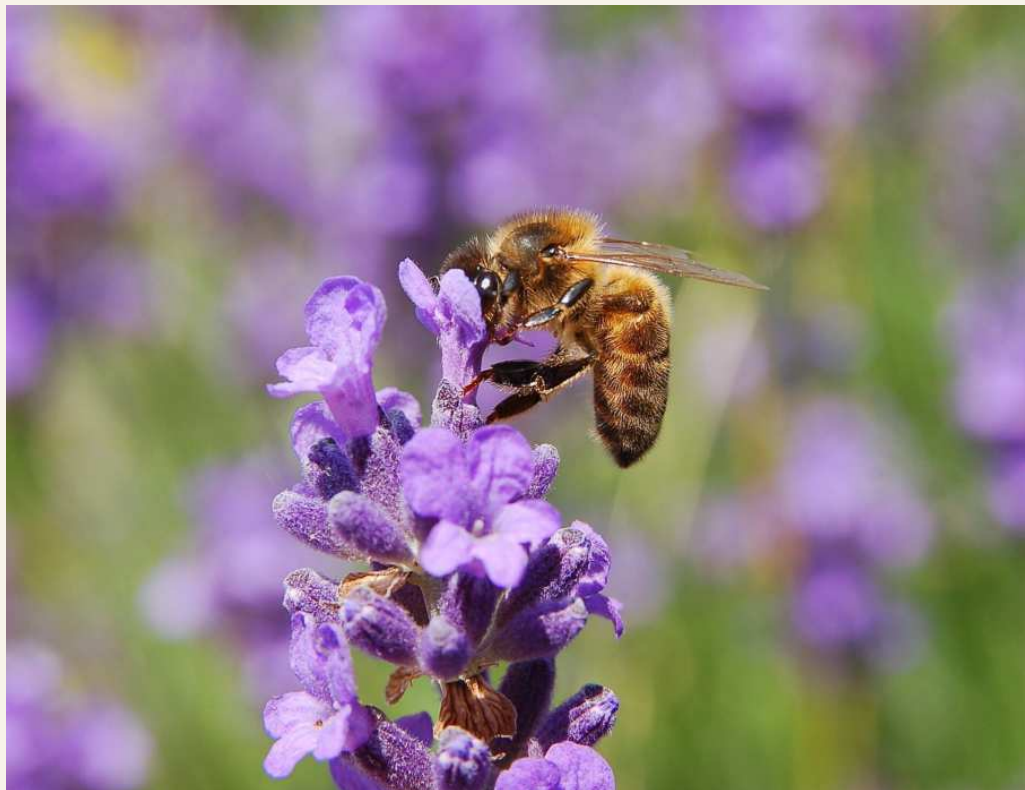
How are they today?

One season does not tell the story of every hive.

Bees do not all experience the same situation. One colony can thrive in a flower-rich place and face difficulties elsewhere. Honey, moreover, tells only part of the story. The National Honey Observatory's report on the 2025 season describes an Italian production that is recovering, but very different from region to region, and market challenges that still persist. Behind the national average there are territories, seasons and works that are very different.

THE DATA, WITH THE YEAR

Season 2025: production recovering, with strong territorial variability. Source: National Honey Observatory, report published in 2026.



When They Are Well

A long-lasting flowering meadow provides food at different times. A water source, a varied environment, and a hive that is carefully monitored help the colony face the season. “Being well does not mean never having problems. It means being able to rely on resources and on a beekeeper who can read the signals and intervene when needed. Good news often consists of regular, patient actions.”

ALARM BELL



When Flowers Are Missing

Imagine arriving at the market and finding the shelves empty. For a bee this can happen when a bloom ends early or an environment offers few flowers. Persistent rains can also prevent them from flying on the right days. A colony has stores, but not infinite ones. The problem has no single cause: local conditions, bee health, and the course of the season intertwine.

ALARM BELL

This scene represents a local condition; on its own it does not prove a loss of hives.

TO OBSERVE

Seasons Change Pace



IN OUR TERRITORY

**Each bloom has
its own timing.**

If a plant flowers earlier than usual, bees may encounter it at a different time than expected. If it rains for days during the bloom, the nectar can become unreachable. Heat and drought can reduce the available resources. A changing climate increases pressure on plants, bees, and beekeepers, but every territory has its own story. Understanding it requires repeated observations, not just a single snapshot.

SOURCE



A difficult guest

Varroa is a tiny mite that lives at the expense of bees and reproduces in the cells where new bees develop. It can weaken the colony and promote the spread of viruses. For this reason the beekeeper monitors the presence of the parasite and applies the prescribed measures to limit it. A close-up photograph makes Varroa look huge: in reality it measures only a few millimeters.

Ministry of Health, “Varroatosis” sheet. Monitoring requires expertise and continuity.

LOOK CLOSELY



Who opens the hive

Before lifting a frame, the beekeeper observes. How is the activity at the entrance? Are there stores? Is the queen laying? Are the young bees growing? Every visit should have a purpose. Opening the hive too often disturbs the colony; never looking can cause an important signal to be missed. Experience also lies in knowing when to close it again and let the bees work.

The comb in the beekeeper's hand is a page to read, not just honey to harvest.

IN THE REPORT

A seasonal profession

IN THE COURSE OF THE YEAR

Observe, prepare, wait.

The beekeeper prepares in advance, but cannot order the sun or stop the rain. He moves equipment, checks the health of the hives, pays for materials and labor even when the harvest is low. The Honey Cost report by CREA, referring to 2023-2024 and published in 2026, studies exactly the costs and sustainability of beekeeping businesses. Behind every jar there are choices, expertise and risks.

IN THE REPORT

THE WORD



Many lands, many honeys

Italian beekeeping spans plains, hills, forests and mountains. Plants change, flowering periods change, and honeys change. Some beekeepers keep the hives in the same place; others move them following the blooms: this practice is called nomadism. For this reason, two harvests of the same honey can have different nuances. The territory enters the jar, but first it entered the flight of the bees.

THE WORD

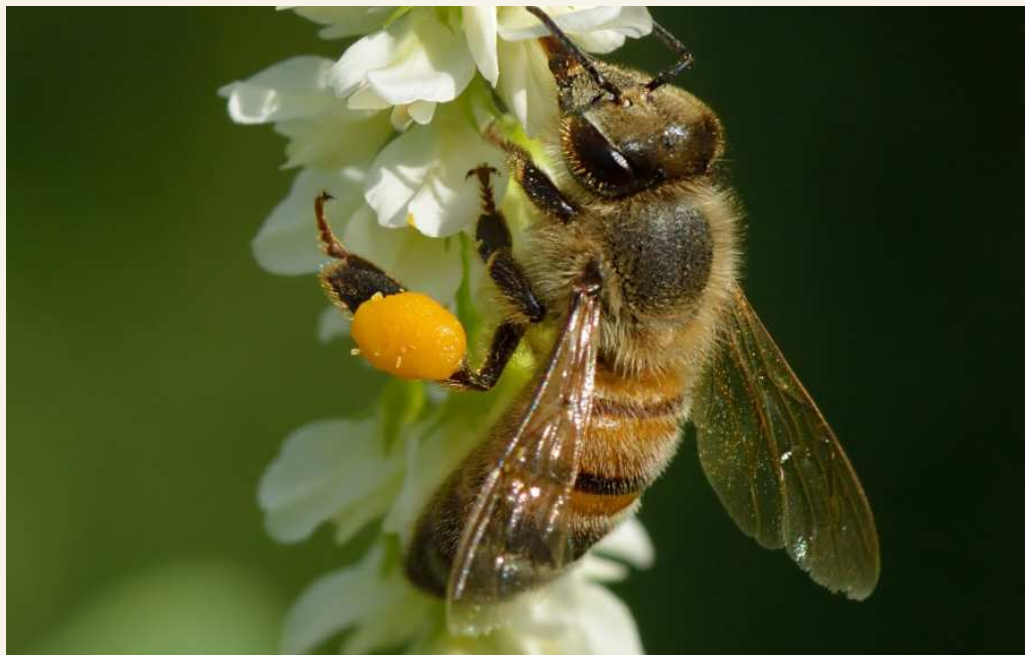


FROM OUR PROJECT

Honey starts from the flowers

Bees collect nectar and bring it to the hive. There they transform it and store it in cells as food reserves. Only honey that can be harvested while respecting the colony's needs reaches us. Color, aroma and texture vary with botanical origin and time. Crystallized honey is not spoiled: crystallization is a natural process.

LOOK CLOSELY



Pollen Bags

Watch a bee leave a flower: on its hind legs it can carry two colored balls. They are loaded with pollen collected and compacted during flight. The colors change according to the flowers visited. In the hive, pollen is an important resource for feeding the colony, especially when new bees are growing. Our interest in this product comes after its role in the life of the hive.

The two balls on the legs can have different shades if the bee has visited different flowers.



Pollen Enters the Comb

A portion of the collected pollen is deposited in the cells. The bees work it together with other hive substances: this is what we call bee bread. In the comb it is not a “display” product, but a store for the family. Cells with different colors also tell the variety of flowers visited. An authentic photograph of this detail is worth more than many definitions.

FIRST THE BEE



Propolis in the Hive

Bees collect resinous substances from plants and process them into propolis. They use it, among other things, to seal small gaps and protect the internal environment of the hive. It is sticky, fragrant, and changes appearance according to the source plants. Only after understanding what it represents for the bees can we observe the preparations humans derive from it, without attributing miraculous powers to them.

In the comb, a crack sealed with propolis is a small act of house maintenance.

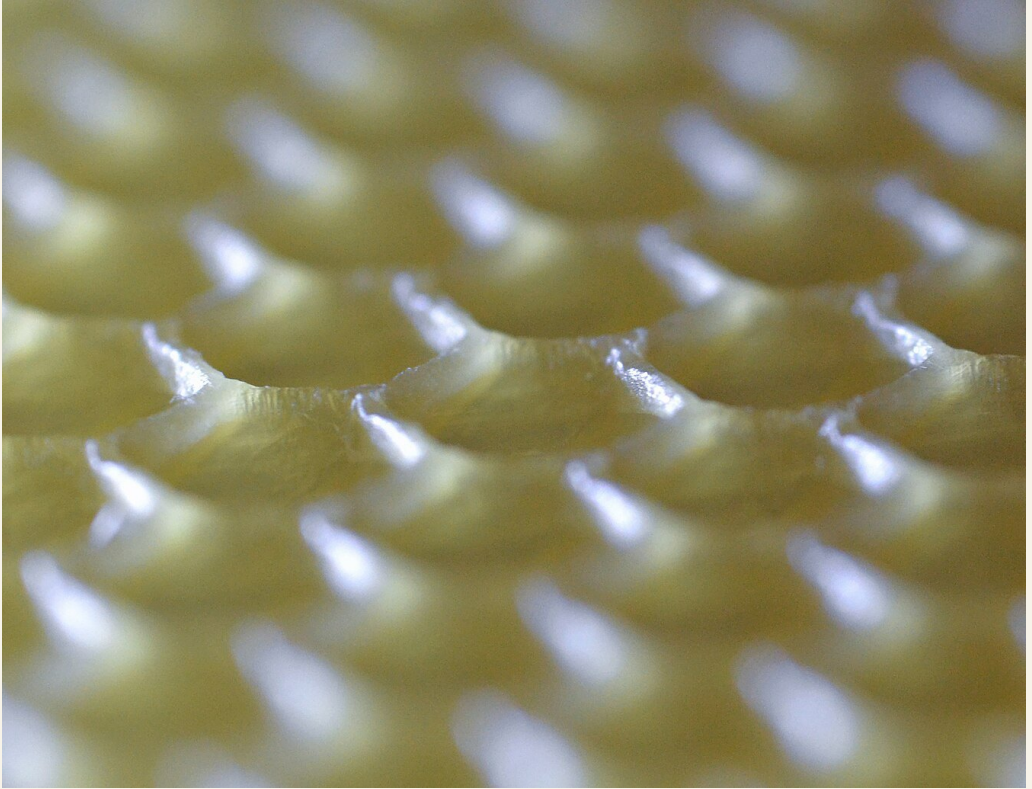
LOOK CLOSELY



The Queens' Food

Royal jelly is produced by young worker bees. It is the nourishment of larvae in the early stages and of the queen throughout her life. Its story takes us to the heart of the colony: caring for the new generations. When talking about the product intended for humans, it is advisable to keep this natural function separate from health claims, which require specific evidence.

A royal cell has a shape different from the normal honeycomb cells.



The Wax House

Worker bees produce wax and build cells with it. The honeycomb is lightweight, but provides space to grow, store pollen, and keep honey. Up close, the hexagons look like a precise design. Yet they are the result of the work of many bees, one next to another. Before becoming a candle or another object, the wax was the structure of their home.

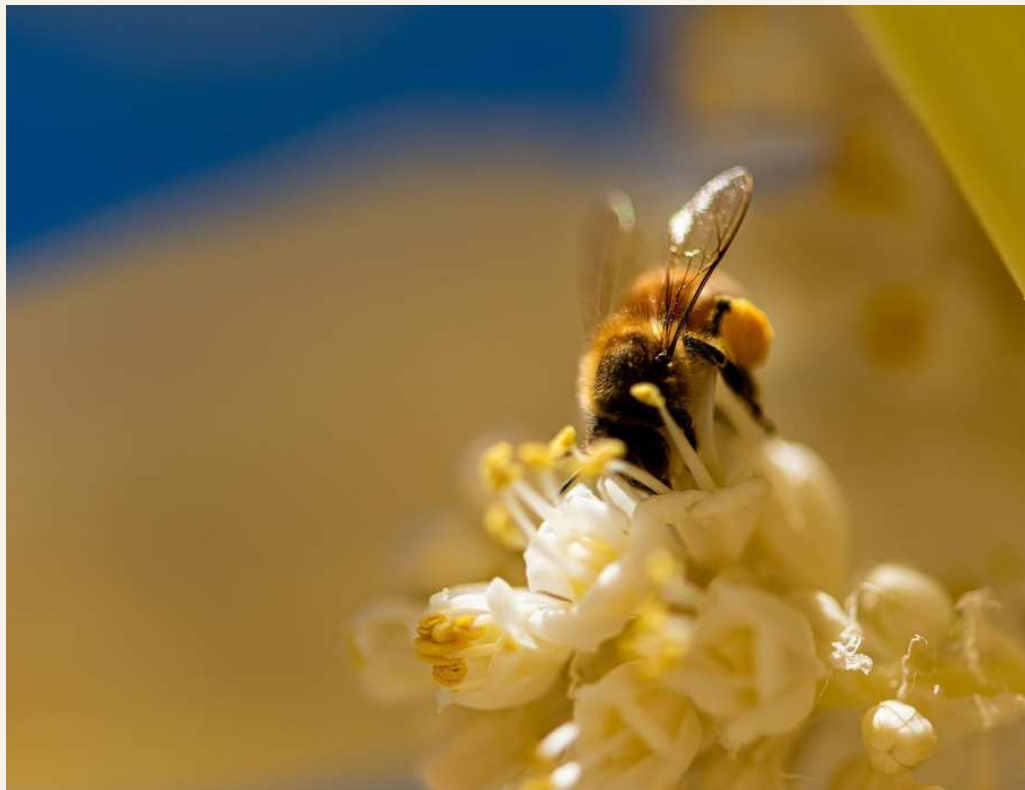
REMEMBER



Why does a bee sting?

The stinger is mainly for defense. Workers can use it when they perceive a threat to themselves or the colony. A sting can cause even severe reactions in sensitive people: it is best to keep distance and stay calm near hives. Bee venom is studied and appears in some dedicated formulations, but this story does not authorize health promises. Here we start from its role for the bee.

If a person experiences significant symptoms after a sting, they should seek medical assistance immediately.



Bees Near Us

You don't need a long trip to meet a bee. It can be in a garden, a park, or on a flowered balcony. Watching it up close without touching it is already a way to get to know it. Not every yellow-and-black insect is a bee; and not all bees live in hives managed by humans. The world of pollinators is more varied than it seems.

TRY OBSERVING



A useful gesture

Choose plants that bloom at different times. Leave, where possible, a few less tidy corners. If you provide water, use a shallow container with stones where insects can perch. Always follow the guidelines for plant treatments. When faced with a swarm, avoid spontaneous actions and contact a beekeeper or the competent local service. Small repeated choices can change a place.

TRY OBSERVING

Which flowers are visited in your neighborhood? Note the month and take photos without disturbing.

SUBMIT YOUR STORY



The territory tells a story

A rediscovered bloom, a meadow cut at the wrong time, a beekeeper at work: these are stories that deserve attention. This page opens a space for readers. A useful report includes the location, date, and what was observed. A photograph helps, but it is not enough to determine the cause of a colony loss or diagnose a hive problem. The testimonies will be verified before being published.

SUBMIT YOUR STORY

Your questions

Every question is an
invitation to observe better.

Do bees sleep? They have periods of rest. Why do they return home? They use the sun, scents and landmarks. Do all of them sting? No: drones have no stinger, and many bees do not sting unless disturbed. How long does a worker live? It depends on the time of year and the work she does. The simplest questions are often the ones that open the best stories.

La Galena delle Api



ALVEOTERAPIA INTEGRATA · GALENA DELLE API

At Castel d'Ario, La Galena delle Api is a place to get closer to the world of the hive. The common thread is the Alveoterapia Integrata: getting to know the bees, observing what they produce and experiencing through dedicated systems. Here you also find dedicated systems that accompany the discovery of hive-related scents. The route invites you to pause, observe and listen: every product and every object become an opportunity to return to the story of the bees.

A REAL PLACE

From the hive to people



LA GALENA DELLE API • CASTEL D'ARIO

After seeing how bees gather, build, and protect the colony, the hive products take on a new meaning. Honey, pollen, propolis, and wax tell different stories. At La Galena you can also discover prepared items and dedicated lines, including the Linea Veleni. The story always starts with the bee: an object on a shelf becomes interesting when we know which bee's action gave rise to it.

TWO SEASONS / ONE STORY

The hive all year round



SPRING / SUMMER AUTUMN / WINTER

In spring and summer the experience can get close to real hives in their natural environment. In autumn and winter it continues inside the spaces of La Galena delle Api, through dedicated systems. These are two ways of meeting the same story, with different conditions and modalities. The year-round hive experience is an invitation to knowledge, observation, and respect for bees.



The two experiences belong to the same project and follow the rhythm of the seasons.

TWO SEASONS



Something bigger

A bee on a flower may seem like a tiny scene. But around it there is a territory, the work of a beekeeper, the plants that provide food to other animals and people capable of making careful choices. We cannot solve everything with a single act. However, we can learn to observe, recognize the real problems and cultivate what works. The story of bees also concerns the landscape we share.

LET'S CONTINUE TOGETHER

See you soon, and goodbye until the next edition!

This issue ends, but the journey continues. There are still stories to tell, photographs to observe, and questions to ask. You might also see one of your images or your testimony in the next issue. Write to us: photos, reports, ideas and suggestions are welcome.

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